



School Trustee Candidate Responses

September 28, 2026

The BVTU invited school trustee candidates to answer questions about their candidacy. Candidate wording is retained exactly as submitted; repeated survey questions and copied formatting have been removed. New candidates and incumbent trustees were sent different questions. The response deadline was September 26, 2026. Candidates are grouped by the voting zone they are running in, then listed alphabetically by surname.



1 • FIND YOUR ZONE

Scan to open the zone map
and enter your address.

bvtu.ca/trustee-zones.html

2 • FIND YOUR CANDIDATES

Candidates are grouped by
zone below. Names and page
numbers are clickable.

3 • SEE THE QUESTIONS

Page 2 lists each survey
question in full, once.
Answers use short tags like
Q4.

CANDIDATES BY ZONE

Zone 1 Lake Kathlyn / Evelyn / Witset

1 seat

[Jessica Michell](#) p. 3

[Priscilla Michell](#) Incumbent no response

Zone 2 Smithers / Glentanna / Driftwood

3 seats

[Phil Briennesse](#) p. 5

[Frank Farrell](#) Incumbent p. 7

[Kristina Graham](#) Incumbent p. 8

[Diane Mackay](#) p. 9

[Casda Thomas](#) p. 10

Zone 3 Telkwa / Quick

1 seat

[Rod Taylor](#) p. 12

[Kim Unger](#) p. 13

Zone 4 Houston

2 seats

[Kellie Dondale](#) p. 15

[Sharon Redford](#) p. 16

[Jennifer Williams](#) Incumbent declined

[Matt Williamson](#) p. 17

The questions

New candidates and incumbent trustees received different surveys. Each question is printed in full here, once; candidate pages use the short tags.

New candidates

- Q1** Why are you running for SD54 school trustee?
- Q2** Who would you describe as “key education partners” in SD54, and do you think engaging with these partners regularly is important to the work of a school trustee?
- Q2(a)** The BC School Trustees Association describes the role of trustees this way: trustees “listen to their communities, guide the work of their school district” (BCSTA, Trustee Responsibilities, bcsta.org/trustee-responsibilities). Do you agree that community voices should guide the work of the district, and how will you regularly engage with community voices to inform your work?
- Q3** If you hold a different opinion than district staff or other board members, how might you raise your concerns while respecting the board’s final decision?
- Q4** Would you vote in favour of live streaming board meetings? Why or why not?
- Q5** Bonus: Please share a positive memory of when an educator made a difference in your life.

Three candidates (Briennesse, Dondale, Unger) answered Q2 and Q2(a) together.

Incumbent trustees

- Q1** How many 4-year terms have you been a trustee, and why are you running again?
- Q2** Please share a time when you did one or more of the following (respond to one or as many as you like): (a) visited a classroom to see what teaching and learning is like in SD54; (b) heard another trustee’s question and response during a Board meeting which caused you to change your mind; (c) voted against a motion.
- Q3** Who would you describe as “key education partners” in SD54, and do you think engaging with these partners regularly is important to the work of a school trustee?
- Q3(a)** The BCSTA quotation above, followed by: Do you agree that community voices should guide the work of the district, and how *have* you regularly engaged with community voices to inform your work?
- Q4** Would you vote in favour of live streaming board meetings? Why or why not?
- Q5** Bonus: Please share a positive memory of when an educator made a difference in your life.

Zone 1

Lake Kathlyn / Evelyn / Witset · 1 seat to be elected

On the ballot: Jessica Michell, Priscilla Michell (incumbent)

No response received

Incumbent trustee **Priscilla Michell** did not respond to the BVTU's invitation to answer the survey questions.

NEW CANDIDATE · ZONE 1

Jessica Michell

Q1

Q2

Q2(a)

Q3

Q4

Q5

Q1 Why are you running for trustee?

I am running for school board trustee as I believe my passion for education as a parent will bring my passion to the table. As a formally educated teacher and college instructor, I also feel passionate to help advocate for our teachers as the governance level. My passion for education will assist in the foundation of our community and our future generation. As a Witsuwit'en matriarch I feel the need to ensure a passionate voice and diverse perspectives are fairly represented. I truly hope for transparency between the school district and our local families and a well-planned out strategic plan.

Q2 Who are SD54's key education partners?

When I think of Key Education Partners in SD54 I think of the "stakeholders" within the community, including our BV Teachers Union, BCTF, Local rights holders (Witset First Nation, Lake Babine Nation and surrounding communities that have children in our schools). Including the First Nations Educations Council. Parent Advisory councils are also apart of the equation, as involving the parents of the children is very important. Lastly, I think the municipal government can be included for collaboration, community representation and common goals.

Q2(a) Should community voices guide the district, and how will you engage?

As a community member and a leader within the Witset community, I feel I am very approachable when it comes to advocacy. As a parent of Smithers Secondary School and Walnut I feel I have a lot of connection to other parents at those schools. Having regular communication and open dialogue will allow for me to fulfil that responsibility. I also feel my experience as a teacher will assist me in understanding teacher concerns and allow me to advocate for those voices as required. As a Witsuwit'en matriarch I also feel it is important to have a voice for one of the most vulnerable populations within the school district being Indigenous students. As a Smithers Secondary graduate and previous student, I feel the urgency to be the voice that this population needs.

Q3 How would you raise a differing opinion?

I believe in using my voice at the table when advocacy is needed. Having my governance experience within my community as Witset council, has allowed for me to be an advocate and having difficult conversations while also being respectful.

Q4 Would you vote for live streaming board meetings?

Yes I would be open to having board meetings livestreamed, as that gives opportunity for trustees to be accountable and for transparency for community.

Q5 Bonus: an educator who made a difference

I have a vivid memory of my final year of high school at Smithers Secondary. A teacher was walking by and saw me sitting in Communications 12, she walked in and pulled me from the course. Marched me down to the counsellor's office and asked that they move me to English Literature. (Which at the time there were 3 streams of English: Communications, English and English Literature). That advocacy allowed for me to go straight from High School into Post Secondary. I can positively name a few teachers in my K-12 experience that advocated hard for me and I am thankful to share those stories now. Awitza!

Zone 2

Smithers / Glentanna / Driftwood · 3 seats to be elected

On the ballot: Phil Briennesse, Frank Farrell (incumbent), Kristina Graham (incumbent), Diane Mackay, Casda Thomas

NEW CANDIDATE · ZONE 2

Phil Briennesse

Q1

Q2 + 2(a)

Q3

Q4

Q5

Q1 Why are you running for trustee?

I am running for school trustee because I have heard from parents, teachers and community user groups who feel disconnected from the Board and have had difficulty getting information, having their concerns heard, or navigating the district. I believe we can do better.

I want to help build a culture of greater transparency, accountability and collaboration. In particular, I am concerned about the relationship between the Board, administration and teachers. These should be partners working toward the same goal: providing the best possible education for our students.

I also believe we need to look creatively at how we support students in the early grades. K–3 is a critical period for establishing the foundation for lifelong learning, yet teachers are often trying to meet increasingly diverse needs without adequate classroom support. I want to explore how SD54 can better direct its resources toward early intervention and meaningful classroom supports.

After seven years on Smithers Council, I understand both the responsibility of elected representatives and the importance of listening before making decisions. I want to bring that experience to the Board and help make SD54 more open, collaborative and responsive to the community it serves.

Q2 + 2(a) Key education partners and community voices (answered together)

Our key education partners include students and families, teachers and support staff, school administrators, PACs, the BVTU, Indigenous education partners, community organizations, user groups and the broader community. Each brings a different perspective, and all have a role to play in building a strong public education system.

I absolutely agree that community voices should help guide the work of the district. BCSTA describes trustees as people who listen to their communities and guide the work of their school district, and I believe meaningful listening has to be an ongoing process, not something that happens only when a major decision is being made.

As a trustee, I would make a point of regularly meeting with education partners and creating opportunities for people to raise concerns before decisions are made. Just as importantly, information needs to flow back to the community. People cannot provide meaningful input if they do not know what is being considered or where to find the relevant information.

My goal would be to help make community engagement a normal part of how the Board operates rather than something that depends on individual trustees. If existing processes are not providing meaningful opportunities for engagement, I would work to improve them and, where necessary, seek out those conversations myself.

Q3 How would you raise a differing opinion?

I think disagreement is an important part of good decision-making. If everyone around the table always agrees, we are probably not hearing enough different perspectives.

If I disagreed with district staff or another trustee, I would raise my concerns respectfully, ask questions, listen carefully to the information being presented, and explain the reasons for my position. My experience on Smithers Council taught me that I can strongly disagree with someone while still respecting them and working with them toward a better solution.

I also recognize that I may not have all the information. There have been times when I went into a Council meeting intending to vote one way and, through discussion and new information, changed my mind. That is not a weakness in decision-making; it is part of the reason we have a board.

Ultimately, trustees are elected to participate in the collective governance of the district. I would stand up for my convictions and for concerns raised by the community, but once the Board has made a decision, I would respect that decision and work constructively with the other trustees to implement it.

Q4 Would you vote for live streaming board meetings?

Yes. I would support live-streaming Board meetings and making recordings available afterward.

For many parents, teachers and community members, attending a Board meeting in person simply isn't practical. Livestreaming would make it much easier for people to understand how decisions are discussed and made, and recorded meetings would allow people to go back and review a particular discussion.

Meeting minutes are important, but they generally record decisions rather than the full discussion that led to them. Public access to the actual conversation provides a much clearer picture of the questions being asked, the information being considered and the different perspectives around the table.

I also think transparency needs to extend to meeting materials. Agenda packages, reports and the policies being considered should be easy for the public to find in one place. If the Board has access to information in preparing for a decision, the public should have access to the appropriate public portions of that same information. Making the process easier to follow would strengthen both public participation and accountability.

Q5 Bonus: an educator who made a difference

Many educators have made a difference in my life, but the one who comes to mind first is my high school English teacher. He taught me perhaps the most important lesson I took from school: how to think critically, form my own opinions, and support those opinions with evidence and facts. He was also the person who first got me interested in politics and community involvement.

While I was in high school, the school board was considering cuts to Educational Assistant funding. Many students felt that this was the wrong place to make cuts. The Board held an open house, and my English teacher encouraged me to speak about how those cuts would affect students.

I was one of only a few students who spoke that evening. I remember feeling that my voice actually mattered and that I could have an impact on decisions affecting my school.

That experience stayed with me. It helped inspire my involvement in local government and community organizations, and it is one of the reasons I believe so strongly that students, parents, teachers and community members should feel that their voices are heard. I want young people in SD54 to have that same sense that they can participate in their community and make a difference.

INCUMBENT TRUSTEE · ZONE 2

Frank Farrell

Q1 Q2 Q3 Q3(a) Q4 Q5

Q1 Terms served, and why are you running again?

Thank you for the opportunity to answer these important questions that your membership can see.

I have served 2 - 3 year terms and 3-4 year terms. My reasons for running for another term is to offer an experienced voice during a very important juncture in education in this province and district. There are serious concerns about funding and the cost to educate our students with our increasing inflationary times. Moreover, it seems that advocacy in ensuring students, all students, are in access to a safe inclusive and relevant education experience that includes the core competencies. Finally, with such emerging technologies as AI I offer my name as an experienced voice to lobby and steward an education system that is supportive of students' need to adapt to a future working world that may be far different than is existing today.

Q2 A classroom visit, a changed mind, or a vote against

(a) Normally, I don't visit while in session. I feel that infringes on student learning of the curriculum of the class. I visited a classroom to read a book to an elementary school class as a part of a special event. Moreover, I have had numerous visits to schools by invitation during special events like Pie night at Walnut Park, Breakfast and Books at Muheim, along with Pride day at Smithers Secondary. I also attend regular PAC meetings at Muheim and Walnut Park.

(b) Firstly, I would like to say that there have been numerous times where Trustees have offered me insight that I have never envisioned. That is a great part of a well balanced board of education. Different backgrounds representing the community as a whole. Specifically, I have been amazed by the insight that has attained through Indigenous learning gained through listening to Trustee Michell.

(c) one particular time I voted against a motion is when I forwarded a motion to refuse a percentage hike in the Trustee Stipend. My thought was that no pay raise should be accepted unless all employees at the District have received a comparable or higher raise

Q3 Who are SD54's key education partners?

Firstly, our union partners BVTU and CUPE. Our Principals and Vice-Principals, and our exempt staff. In addition our stakeholder groups the community including parents through public consultation and participation at PAC meetings. Moreover, Provincially, we engage organizations as the BC School Trustees Association BCPublic School Employers Association. Employers. Finally we engage with students by attending invited events.

Q3(a) Should community voices guide the district, and how have you engaged?

No separate answer provided to this question.

Q4 Would you vote for live streaming board meetings?

Yes if it is cost effective and doesn't take money away from student learning.

Q5 Bonus: an educator who made a difference

There have been numerous instances when an educator made a difference in my life both as a student and as a parent. From my time as a student perhaps my most inspirational moment was as a grade 6. student of Helen Tulk Elementary School Bishops Falls , Newfoundland and Labrador,when the staff helped to organize a visit from an unknown man by the name of Terry Fox as he was on the early stages of his Marathon of Hope. Terry ran up the main street with students and proceeded to Inglis Memorial High School across the street. Terry spoke to the hundreds of students, staff and onlookers. What I got from the experience was anything is possible.

From the parent perspective the work of all educators that taught my kids have been immeasurable. One instance was when I was a newer Trustee I had the honor of hosting an Education Forum where the topic was reading comprehension of elementary students of Walnut Park. Mrs Hooper and Rutley gave the presentation and insisted you will like this. I certainly did as the video portion of the presentation included students showing their reading comprehension. The last student was my son. I will remember both moments the rest of my life.

INCUMBENT TRUSTEE · ZONE 2

Kristina Graham

Q1

Q2

Q3

Q3(a)

Q4

Q1 Terms served, and why are you running again?

One - 4 year term. This is an important job and I feel there is still a lot of work to be done.

Q2 A classroom visit, a changed mind, or a vote against

No answer provided to this question.

Q3 Who are SD54's key education partners?

I believe community engagement is an important role and not just within the district, but the town itself.

Q3(a) Should community voices guide the district, and how have you engaged?

Being a face in our community, I have had members reach out with both compliments and complaints. I have taken concerns back to the board office and directed community members to who is best to field their needs.

Q4 Would you vote for live streaming board meetings?

I don't see a problem with this.

NEW CANDIDATE · ZONE 2

Diane Mackay

Q1

Q2

Q2(a)

Q3

Q4

Q5

Q1 Why are you running for trustee?

I have been interested in the school trustee position since the 1990's when my children were in elementary school. My life was busy as I worked full-time and was raising 7 children from a blended family. At one point I had children in day care, at Muheim Elementary, Chandler Park Middle School and SSS. Now that I am retired and have grandchildren in local schools, I felt I could finally commit the time and effort. Two priorities that have been constant in my life are children and education. Most of my experiences as a parent have been positive - teachers have been supportive, principals have been fair and everyone worked together to move my children through school. My belief is that the students in school now are the future of our community and the best way we can prepare them is to provide the best education in a supportive environment.

Q2 Who are SD54's key education partners?

Some of the partnerships would be the district schools, and within those the local Parents Advisory Councils, as well as the Ministry of Education and Child Care and the Child Development Centre. Another important partnership would be the BV Teachers Union. Future partnerships could include the Child Development Centre, to stay current on educational practices and support resources.

Q2(a) Should community voices guide the district, and how will you engage?

Community voices are key to knowing what is happening in the schools and what is important for school boards to focus on in regards to the strategic vision. I believe trustees should meet with local PAC's, attend school functions as representatives of the board, be involved with some of the committees that fall under the Ministry of Education and Child Care (Indigenous learning, for example), and cultivate relationships with the Child Development Centre. The teachers union could be the contact point for getting information to the teachers, but also hearing from them what is happening in the classrooms and the challenges they face.

Q3 How would you raise a differing opinion?

Having been on many committees, boards, and working groups over my career - I have observed that some of the best results come from having different views and opinions. It allows the healthy discussion and debate required to fully understand problems and solutions before decisions are reached. Once a decision is reached, all members should be supportive of implementing the decision.

Q4 Would you vote for live streaming board meetings?

Not having served on the school board before, I am unsure of how I would vote in the matter of live streaming meetings. I would assume that some discussions would be private, but most could be public. I have watched the Town of Smithers meetings and appreciate that opportunity. One thing I thought was a great idea was when the local newspaper published the votes by each councilor and their reasons why. This gave great insight into issues and initiatives, and provided some transparency to the public.

Q5 Bonus: an educator who made a difference

One particular educator that I would say had a lasting impact on my life was Mrs. Dorothy Wandler, my teacher in grade 4 and 5. Part of this was due to her encouragement, guidance and praise when we were just learning how to write reports. She made me want to strive towards excellence in all my educational endeavours. Another area where she differed from other teachers of the day (1970's) was in how she corrected behaviour in the classroom without shaming. I believe that impacted how I parented later in life, and also how I treated disciplinary measures with staff over the years.

NEW CANDIDATE · ZONE 2

Casda Thomas[Q1](#) [Q2](#) [Q2\(a\)](#) [Q3](#) [Q4](#) [Q5](#)**Q1** Why are you running for trustee?

With two kids attending Muheim Elementary School, a heart for my community and experience in elected office, running for school trustee feels like an obvious choice for me.

My kids are involved in many sports and arts activities and over the years I have become actively involved in their activities, coaching both softball and hockey. This has grown my connection to the community even more by allowing me to meet all sorts of great kids and parents that I only had the opportunity to meet through coaching.

More formally, I have always valued democracy and civic engagement. I have been involved in various ways over the years. Early in my time in Smithers, I spent several years on the Town's Advisory Planning Commission. I was then elected to Smithers Town Council and served in that capacity from 2018-2022. At that time, I chose not to run for a second term due to family commitments, but my commitment to civic engagement has remained and now I am ready to represent my community at the school board table.

Q2 Who are SD54's key education partners?

I strongly believe in engaging with partners and the public. My current role with the BC Wildfire Service is in community engagement and I have previously served a term on Smithers town council where I highly valued engagement with partners and community members.

Key educational partners for the school district would include:

- Teachers and school counselors,
- Educational assistants and other school-level staff,
- School-level leadership,
- Students, student groups and student body representatives,
- Parents, guardians and parent groups, such as the local PACs.

Other community members also play vital roles in guiding and supporting youth and may also be defined as partners including, for example, community organizations, coaches and instructors, to name just a few.

Q2(a) Should community voices guide the district, and how will you engage?

I believe that engaging with the community is a core part of an elected official's role. I don't see myself as an expert or someone who inherently has all the answers, but rather as a conduit between the community and the school district.

I commit to being transparent about decision making, and available for dialogue with partners and community members.

Q3 How would you raise a differing opinion?

Having a group of trustees that can hold and discuss different opinions is good; it's how we arrive at the best decisions possible. And fostering a culture of curiosity and respectful debate is healthy.

When I served on Smithers town council, I regularly asked questions, voiced opinions and listened to what other councillors had to say. Sometimes what I said influenced our direction, other times something that another person said caused me to reconsider my position.

I commit to sharing my perspective with the other trustees at the board table and to listening to their opinions with an open mind. This does not mean compromising my values. It means being open to different ways of arriving at the best possible outcomes.

Q4 Would you vote for live streaming board meetings?

Yes, I would be in favour of live streaming board meetings.

This was the practice when I was on council and it was an excellent way for residents to engage at a level that worked for them. Few people have the time in their lives to attend board meetings but making them available online makes the meetings so much more accessible.

Q5 Bonus: an educator who made a difference

Mrs. Forrest, my grade seven homeroom and English teacher. There's not one big thing that she did that sticks out for me, rather it was many small things that created a secure foundation for my first year in middle school. I don't even think I realized or appreciated it at the time, but she is the teacher that consistently comes to mind when I think about my school years.

She was strict, but also kind and calm. She asked us questions, respected our autonomy, and taught us about 'real world things' like personal wellbeing and compounding interest (this was not normal at the time!) If a student had menstrual cramps, they were free to leave the class and take care of themselves, and she would offer help discreetly, but without shame.

She wasn't everyone's favourite teacher, it was quieter than that, she modeled stability, students respected her. She somehow created a safe space for all of us to just settle, be ourselves and let go of the constant pressure to fit in.

Zone 3

Telkwa / Quick · 1 seat to be elected

On the ballot: Rod Taylor, Kim Unger

NEW CANDIDATE · ZONE 3

Rod Taylor

Q1 Q2 Q2(a) Q3 Q4 Q5

Q1 Why are you running for trustee?

The education of our young people is one of the most important responsibilities we have as a society. Young people today—who will be the pillars of society in only a few short years—deserve the best tools and training with which to succeed. I want to see them properly equipped to understand their world and to take their places in it.

Q2 Who are SD54's key education partners?

Students and their parents are at the centre of the education partnership. Teachers, of course, are the trusted partners with whom parents and students should have a positive relationship. Teachers, in turn, need a supportive administration team and that ultimately involves the board of trustees and other members of the community. Of course, many students are also instructed and influenced in their local churches / spiritual communities and in the clubs or teams to which they may belong.

Q2(a) Should community voices guide the district, and how will you engage?

Yes, I intend to be available to hear from the community and especially from parents. Nobody has a higher stake in the success and wellbeing of the children than their own parents.

Q3 How would you raise a differing opinion?

It's likely that there will be differences of opinion. That's why we elect boards or groups of representatives rather than just one person. We learn from each other and the goal is to find good solutions through the sharing of ideas and perspectives. It is my goal to communicate my thoughts and perspectives in a respectful manner.

Q4 Would you vote for live streaming board meetings?

I think so; I'd want to listen to the views of other board members first. I do believe in transparency so I don't see any reason not to make the meetings accessible to the public.

Q5 Bonus: an educator who made a difference

I've been privileged to have a number of good educators / mentors in my life. I still do. My first educators, of course, were my Mom and Dad who both had a lasting and positive impact on my life. I also remember particularly my grade 2 teacher, my grade 6 teacher and my grade 7 teacher. My grade 6 teacher really boosted my confidence and encouraged me. There's no doubt that a teacher can inspire, motivate and encourage a young person to learn and to achieve great things.

NEW CANDIDATE · ZONE 3

Kim Unger

Q1

Q2 + 2(a)

Q3

Q4

Q5

Q1 Why are you running for trustee?

I am running for Zone 3 (Telkwa/ Quick) school trustee because I care about our public schools and believe every child has the right to a quality education in a safe/ supported environment from the moment they get on the school bus/ are dropped off at the school to the end of the school day. I feel I would make a great trustee because of my background in education and my connections with the schools and community. I am friendly, organized, compassionate, and always strive to think outside the box for collaborative solutions. Also, this opportunity comes at a time when I am working part time and my kids are at the age where they are a bit more independent and I can dedicate the time that the role of school trustee deserves.

Q2 + 2(a) Key education partners and community voices (answered together)

Key education partners in the community are of course the staff and families of the students who attend our public schools. There are also various businesses and organizations with which the board could connect and collaborate, including local government, libraries, museums, community services, First Nations, sports clubs, special interest groups, farms, and emergency services to name a few. If elected as trustee, I would encourage community members to reach out to me with concerns and ideas to bring to the board. People who know me know that I love making connections!

Q3 How would you raise a differing opinion?

If I had the honour to have a seat at the board table, I would express my opinion even if it differed from the district staff's opinions or another board member's. Afterall, the purpose of the board having 7 members is so that no one person is making important decisions about the future of the school district and individual student needs. I realize that these conversations won't always be comfortable, but I believe we can work collaboratively to reach a consensus that fits with the board values and has students' best interests in mind. Once that decision is made, I would respect it knowing that my voice was heard along with 6 other voices and the communities we represent.

Q4 Would you vote for live streaming board meetings?

Board meetings are already open to the public so live streaming would simply make them more accessible, which I think is important considering the size of the district, winter road conditions, and the fact that many people who may want to attend them are parents who could then live stream from home without needing to arrange childcare. I do think it warrants a discussion on whether the live stream would be open to the whole world or whether there would be a way to allow only district residents to access the live stream.

Q5 Bonus: an educator who made a difference

I have so many positive memories of teachers, but I would have to say my high school French and Spanish teachers had a big impact in my life as my passion for languages and cultures started in their classes. They encouraged me to participate in a 2-month exchange to Quebec in grade 10 and a year-long exchange to

Ecuador after graduating. I then went on to attend university in Japan and South Korea and also volunteered in Brazil, learning a few more languages along the way. Now, I share that passion with my adult EAL learners in my role as Language Instructor/ Assessor at Smithers Community Services Association.

Zone 4

Houston · 2 seats to be elected

On the ballot: Kellie Dondale, Sharon Redford, Jennifer Williams (incumbent), Matt Williamson

Declined to answer

Incumbent trustee **Jennifer Williams** replied to the BVTU but declined to answer the survey questions.

NEW CANDIDATE · ZONE 4

Kellie Dondale

Q1

Q2 + 2(a)

Q3

Q4

Q5

Q1 Why are you running for trustee?

I want to make a change, let kids be heard. What they need to succeed, thrive, find their passion. Some kids need more help than others I also believe that these days more kids need help with their mental health, which leads me to bullying. It's a big problem in schools. I want to get kids the help they need.

Q2 + 2(a) Key education partners and community voices (answered together)

not only are the teachers, EAs, substitutes in this school and other schools important but also the community. Everyone has either went to school in district 54, had a child in district 54 or has a child in district 54. Everyone should be heard. Some opinions might not be suitable but at least we would know how or what some people think. In order to know these answers/ideas I think discussing it with people directly will make a difference, knowing your community will make a difference.

Q3 How would you raise a differing opinion?

Bring up my opinions or thoughts at the monthly meetings, nothing will get heard or done if someone keeps quiet. You can voice your opinion in a kind manor and not disrespect people while doing it.

Q4 Would you vote for live streaming board meetings?

I would definitely vote for live streaming, with the busy lifestyle now adays sometimes it hard to get away, at least with the live stream you can take care of family obligations while completing meetings.

Q5 Bonus: an educator who made a difference

Two people made a difference in my life, Terry kluss and Paul Batley. I went though some rough health issues in high-school and she was there for me every step of the way. Paul Batley always had a good sense of humor and when he would laugh or smile it would make me forget about what I was going through in the background. Im very fortunate to have went to school with them and to this day still talk with them or talk about them.

NEW CANDIDATE · ZONE 4

Sharon Redford

Q1 Q2 Q2(a) Q3 Q4 Q5

Q1 Why are you running for trustee?

They're are many reason I'm running for school trustee:

- gives me the opportunity to listen, strengthen & support my community
- look at my community needs and set goals
- support indigenous student graduation successes
- create more opportunities for students to learn, grow & succeed
- as a trustee help develop strategic plans, set goals, guide decisions & to be fair

Q2 Who are SD54's key education partners?

There are many "key education partners" I've talked to many of them while I worked as an indigenous support worker for SD 54.

- Witset representatives
- Indigenous Ed council representatives
- Wit'suwit'en Nation representatives
- Coast Mountain College representatives

Q2(a) Should community voices guide the district, and how will you engage?

I agree that community voices guide the work of the district. I have the privilege of sitting on the board of directors on the Houston Lhc'et'dli Preservation Society. We meet with community regularly at our bi-monthly luncheon & always look forward to visiting with them

Q3 How would you raise a differing opinion?

If I hold a different opinion I would respectfully voice my concerns

Q4 Would you vote for live streaming board meetings?

Live streaming SD54 board meetings makes sense. I lived in Houston BC for 38 years, worked for SD54 for 25 years, the meetings are always in Smithers. My families face many barriers that many people take for granted.

- meetings are held at 7pm
- have to travel in the dark
- no vehicle or no fuel
- no babysitter for parents to attend

Community needs to be heard & seen

Q5 Bonus: an educator who made a difference

I never knew that both my parents went to residential school. My 4 brothers and I all quit when we were in highschool. My parents didn't care. I quit when I was in grade 11 at PGSS in Prince George. Got married at 19 had 2 kids. By the time I turned 31 years old, I was living in Houston, I wanted my kids to know that education was important. I wanted to get a job and realized that I needed my grade 12 diploma. Bill Arkinstall was the principal at HSS in 1994 and he encouraged me to enroll in the Adult Graduation program to get my Dogwood diploma. I did and started highschool the next day. I sat in classes everyday with all the teenagers. By June of 1995 I walked up for grad with my daughter who was in grade 4 and my son who was in grade 1. All the teachers working there at that time were all encouraging and supportive. Then 3 years later I got the job at Twain Sullivan Elementary as the aboriginal support worker.

NEW CANDIDATE · ZONE 4

Matt Williamson

Q1 Q2 Q2(a) Q3 Q4 Q5

Q1 Why are you running for trustee?

I am running as a candidate for school trustee for a few different reasons.

- Education is important to me, I believe that it is the foundation for building a successful life.
- I'd like to play a role in helping increase scholastic achievement in our district.
- I feel like the district and the board need to be more transparent and engaged with parents.
- On a more personal level, I have children who are or will soon be in the public school system and I am married to an educator, therefore, the quality of the environment which they learn and teach in is important to me.

Q2 Who are SD54's key education partners?

I think that key education partners would first and foremost be the teachers and other district staff who are actually employed in the schools. They are the front line workers in the education system and should have the most encompassing view of the needs of the student body as a whole. Next, would be the parents of the students. I think that parents should have a proactive role in the education of their children in a way that compliments and encourages learning at school. I think that engaging with partners is very important, and I would commit to visiting schools and talking with staff and parents often.

Q2(a) Should community voices guide the district, and how will you engage?

I believe that the voice of the community should carry weight. If people are willing to have open and honest conversations about the education of their children, then that should be a priority and I would really like to see a lot of parental engagement with the board. I think that as trustees, we should not rely solely on things like studies from the provincial government, etc. British Columbia is a vast province with a very diverse population, so what works for a district on Vancouver Island or the Lower Mainland may not necessarily work for our small northern district and the people we serve. Our demographics are different and our logistics are more challenging. For example on logistics, in Vancouver it is only a matter of hopping

on public transit for a Science World field trip during school hours, whereas in the north, we don't have those transportation and destination options without considerable effort from staff and parent committees (not to mention the bussing issues we face here).

Q3 How would you raise a differing opinion?

I tend to try to base my opinions on facts if I can. I would make my case and have the data to back it up. If I had an uninformed opinion, I would first set myself on the task of becoming informed. In the end, if the board made a contrary final decision, I would be required to respect that decision by the rules of the code of conduct for trustees. However, if I believed it was worthwhile, I would revisit the topic as much as practicable.

Q4 Would you vote for live streaming board meetings?

Yes, I think that in this day and age people shouldn't have to drive to the board meeting to observe it. Parents could then more conveniently stay up to date with what the board is doing, which should lead to more engagement. This would also allow people who may not have the means to attend in person the ability to observe. It would also overcome weather related travel concerns between communities. Coincidentally, this could also have a beneficial environmental impact as well if more people watched from home.

Q5 Bonus: an educator who made a difference

There have been so many wonderful educators in my life, each contributing their particular block in the foundation on which I've built my life. One of many experiences that I could share would be the time that I was introduced to computers and programming by my math teacher Mrs. Meutzner. This was in a time before the internet (gasp!). Coding was not taught in school at the time, but she encouraged me to learn how to write programs in a couple of different programming languages and provided me with some resources that weren't available in schools yet. My 12 year old brain could hardly fathom the vast universe of possibilities that lay before me with the new found skills to command a computer! While we take these sorts of things for granted these days, back then it lit a spark that turned into a lifelong interest in computers and electronics. This in turn guided my choices in post secondary education and led me to amateur radio which was the basis of all the emergency communication volunteerism that I continue to pursue to this day!